

PRD: True Shuffle

Product: Spotify Mobile and Desktop

Author: Emily Lazenby

Problem

Spotify's shuffle does not feel random. Users report hearing the same songs repeatedly within a single session while other songs in the same playlist go unplayed entirely. The result is that a 200 song playlist effectively feels like a 100 song playlist. Spotify's algorithm intentionally groups songs by audio similarity including tempo, energy, and danceability, but for users who intentionally built diverse playlists, this feels like Spotify filtering out songs the user already chose to include.

User evidence

Personal listening data across 18,254 streams shows a skip rate pattern where certain tracks accumulate disproportionate play counts relative to their skip rate, suggesting algorithmic surfacing rather than active user selection. I built a playlist of thousands of songs and still hear the same tracks on repeat, while songs I actively enjoy go unplayed for weeks. User sentiment around shuffle is one of Spotify's most consistent pain points across Reddit, Twitter, and app store reviews.

Proposed solution

Introduce a True Shuffle toggle that randomizes playback with no algorithmic weighting. Every song in the queue gets equal probability of being selected regardless of tempo, energy, or previous play history. Once a song plays it is removed from the pool until every song has played once, at which point the pool resets. This sits alongside the existing shuffle as a user choice and does not replace it.

Success metrics

Increase in unique tracks played per session as a percentage of total playlist size. Decrease in skip rate for algorithmically surfaced tracks. Reduction in user complaints about shuffle in app store reviews.

Out of scope

Discover Weekly and Release Radar are unaffected. This does not change default shuffle behavior for users who do not opt in.